

MODULE 16 / 40

Carolina Wren

*Thryothorus ludovicianus***QUICK STATS**

Length	4.7 – 5.5 in (12 – 14 cm)
Wingspan	11.4 in (29 cm)
Weight	0.6 – 0.8 oz (18 – 22 g)
Lifespan	Up to 6 years (avg. 2 in wild)

PRESENTATION

The Carolina Wren is one of the most surprising birds in the backyard — a tiny, round-bodied bird with a cocked tail and a bold white eyebrow stripe that produces one of the loudest songs of any North American bird relative to its size. Its rich, warm rufous plumage, perpetually upturned tail, and restless, energetic movements make it instantly endearing. Unlike most wrens, the Carolina Wren is a year-round resident that forms permanent pair bonds, with mates staying in close contact throughout the year. Pairs duet frequently — the male belting out his ringing "teakettle-teakettle-teakettle" while the female responds with a dry chatter — a remarkable coordination between mates.

HABITAT & RANGE

The Carolina Wren is found year-round across the eastern United States, from Nebraska and southern Iowa east to the Atlantic coast, and from southern Ontario south through Florida and into Central America. It inhabits dense, brushy undergrowth in deciduous and mixed forests, forest edges, thickets, vine tangles, brushy gardens, and overgrown fields. It thrives in suburban and rural gardens with dense shrubs, brush piles, and woody debris. It is highly sensitive to cold winters — severe ice storms can cause dramatic local population crashes, from which recovery takes several years.

DIET & FEEDING

- Suet cakes — the top feeder food for Carolina Wrens
- Peanut butter and peanut pieces
- Mealworms — live or dried, eagerly taken
- Insects and spiders — the bulk of the natural diet year-round
- Small berries and seeds occasionally in winter
- Bark butter (peanut butter-fat mixture) spread on tree trunks

BEHAVIOR & SOCIAL LIFE

Carolina Wrens are intensely curious and remarkably bold for their size. They investigate every nook and cranny of their territory — peering into flowerpots, exploring open garages and porches, and probing bark and leaf litter for insects with their long, curved bills. Unlike many songbirds, Carolina Wrens maintain their pair bond year-round. The male and female remain in constant vocal contact, often duetting together. They are non-migratory and fiercely territorial, defending their home range against other wrens with loud singing and aggressive chases. They roost communally in cold weather, sometimes piling into nest boxes or dense vegetation to conserve warmth.

NESTING & BREEDING

Carolina Wrens are famously eclectic nesters, placing their domed cup nests in almost any sheltered cavity — natural tree holes, old woodpecker cavities, nest boxes, flowerpots, hanging baskets, boots left on a porch, or gaps in outbuildings. The male builds several "dummy" nests that are never used, while the female selects and completes the final nest. Clutches of 4–6 white eggs with reddish-brown speckles are incubated by the female for 12–16 days. Both parents feed the nestlings, which fledge at 12–14 days. Pairs raise 2–3 broods per season.

SONG & COMMUNICATION

The Carolina Wren's song is extraordinarily loud for such a small bird — a clear, ringing "teakettle-teakettle-teakettle" or "cheery-cheery-cheery" that carries 100 meters or more. Males have a repertoire of 27–40 distinct song types and switch between them constantly. Females respond with a buzzy chatter, creating antiphonal duets. Both sexes give a variety of sharp "jimp" and churring alarm calls when disturbed. Song is heard year-round, with intensity peaking in early spring.

CONSERVATION STATUS

IUCN Red List:	Least Concern	Population trend:	Increasing
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The Carolina Wren population is estimated at approximately 14 million individuals and has been expanding northward over recent decades, aided by warming winters. However, it remains vulnerable to severe cold snaps and ice storms — a single harsh winter can eliminate local populations. Providing dense shrub cover, brush piles, suet, and nest boxes are among the most effective ways to support this species through winter.

FEEDER TIPS

- Suet cakes near dense shrubs are the most reliable attraction
- Offer live or dried mealworms in a shallow dish — they adore them
- Brush piles and log piles near the feeder provide essential cover
- A low platform feeder with peanut pieces works well
- Carolina Wrens nest in boxes — a 1.5-inch entrance box near cover often works

COLORING GUIDE

ZONE	RECOMMENDED COLOR
Crown & back	Rich warm brown — rufous tones
Wings & tail	Brown with fine dark barring
Supercilium	Bold white eyebrow stripe
Throat & breast	Buffy white to warm buff
Flanks & belly	Deeper buffy-orange wash
Bill	Long, slender, curved, dark

COLOR ME!

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